
A Twelve-Step Approach to Writing a Research Proposal

Dr. Stephen Zdzinski

Frost School of Music

University of Miami

Background

- Been teaching research methods since 1992 (20 years)
- Taught DMA research classes at UM (10 years)
- Students have trouble converting **researchable ideas** into proposals
 - Come with ideas, but can't translate into proposal format.
 - Systematic Approach Needed
 - Sequencing, sequencing, sequencing
- The **twelve-step** approach
 - came out of teaching research students over 20 years.

Defining Research

- A **systematic approach** to asking and answering questions about something
- Sometimes asking for information to answer question (i.e., Data)
- Systematic
 - ❑ ASKING
 - ❑ GETTING INFO
 - ❑ ANSWERING

Researchable Idea

- Could be ANYTHING
- Defined by
 - ❑ Researcher Interest (chapter 1)
 - ❑ Worthiness (chapter 1)
 - ❑ Manageability (chapter 3)

Proposal Format

- Chapter I, Introduction
 - Background & Justification
 - Purpose & Research Questions
 - Chapter II, Review of Literature
 - Intro
 - Topic, Topic, Topic
 - Implications
 - Chapter III, Method
 - Participants
 - Measures
 - Procedures
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The Proposal Format Simplified

- Purpose:
 - *What's the Point of my Study?*
 - *What are my Research Questions?*
 - Justification:
 - *Why Bother with my Study?*
 - Review of Literature
 - *What do we already know about the topic?*
 - Method
 - *How will I conduct my study?*
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The Twelve Steps

1. Purpose
2. Research Questions
3. Gather Sources
4. Organize Sources
5. Justify
6. Chapter 1
7. Outline Method
8. Chapter 3
9. Outline Literature
10. Chapter 2
11. Revise All
12. Finalize Document

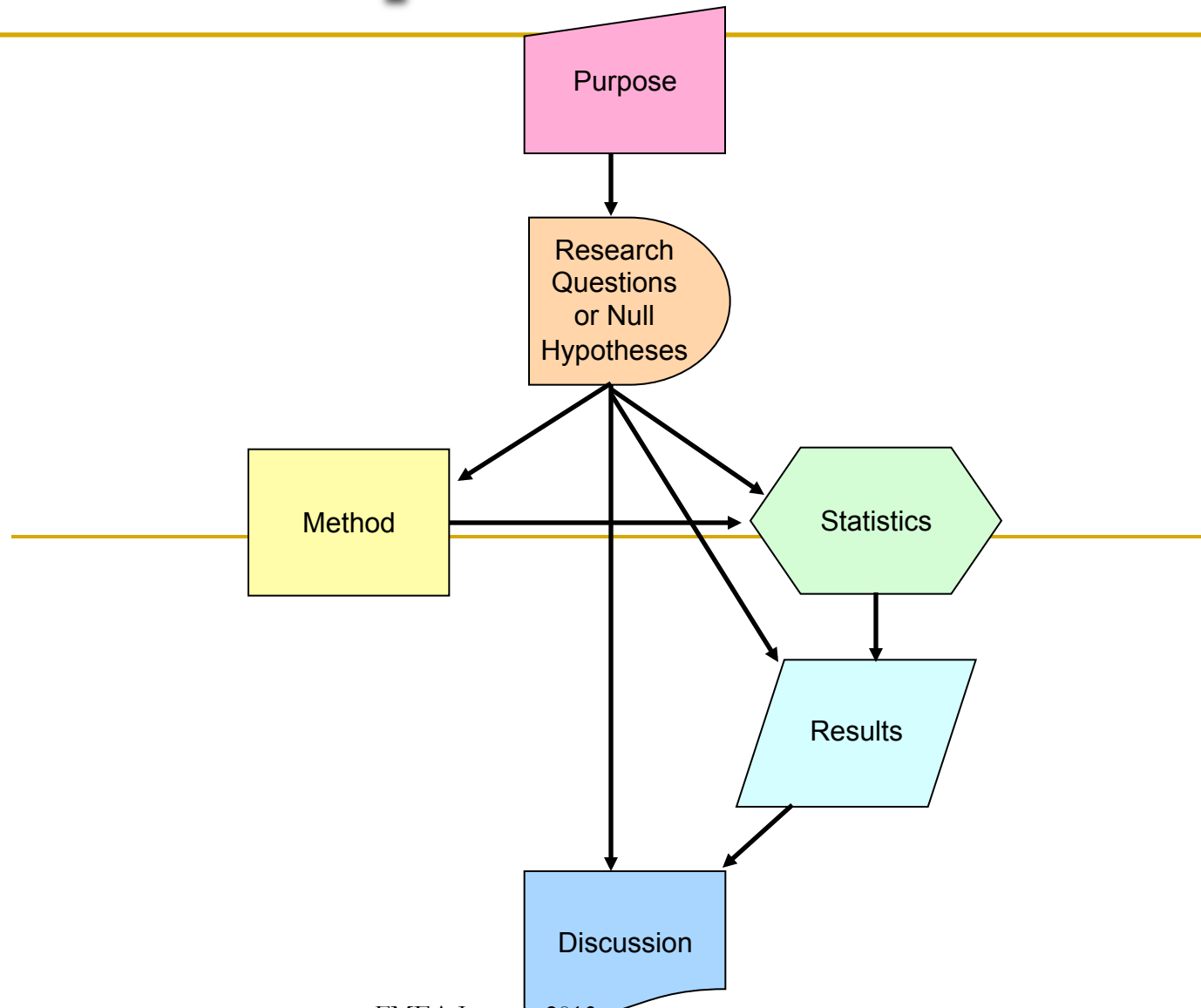
Starting with a Purpose

1. State a specific **purpose** for your study
2. State specific **research questions** related to your specific study purpose

Why Start with Purpose?

- From purpose
 - **research questions** are created
 - **sources** are selected for inclusion (in justification, literature, and method sections according to function)
- From purpose & research questions
 - **method details** are created

The Purpose Thread



Final Word on Purpose

- Purpose matches questions
 - ✓ Good Research
- Purpose matches methodology/stats
 - ✓ Good Research
- Purpose focus of discussion
 - ✓ Good Research
- Purpose focus of conclusion
 - ✓ Good Research

Gathering & Using Sources

3. Gather **sources** related to your Purpose and research questions
4. Take sources and **organize by topic**
 - Sources can be research-based or practitioner-based (or both)
 - used to refine purpose and research questions
 - Used in different ways in each chapter
 - Chapter 1: Justification of purpose
 - Chapter 2: Narrative of what we already know
 - Chapter 3: Justification of Method decisions

Write a Justification, Draft Chapter 1

5. Create a **justification** for your study (line of argument in outline form)
6. From this outline, **Write a Chapter 1** that includes
 1. General Background of the Study
 2. Need for the Study
 3. Research Purpose & Research Questions

Chapter 3 (Method)

7. From the **Research Questions** and **Research Purpose** (#1 & #2), create an **outline of your method**.
 8. From this outline, **Write a Chapter 3** that includes:
 1. Participants
 2. Materials/Measures
 3. Data Gathering Procedures
 4. Data Analysis Procedures
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More on Method

- Participants First
 - Impact selection of measures
- Measures
 - Identify Measures for each variable in study (clear linkage)
- Organize by **Research Question**
 - Data Analyses (clear linkage to research question)
 - Statistics used to ANSWER QUESTION

Chapter 2 (Review of Literature)

9. Create an **outline for your Chapter 2** (Review of Literature)
 10. From this outline, **write a chapter 2** that includes
 1. Introduction of topics to be covered in lit review
 2. Topic 1 Narrative
 3. Topic 2 Narrative, etc.
 4. Summary and Implications for your study
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More on Review of Literature

- Organize Literature in Chapter 2 by RESEARCH QUESTION if practical
- WHY?
 - Compare results of study to previous results from review of literature
 - Used to Create Discussion

Revisions and Refinement

11. **Revise** Chapters 1 & 3 based on new stuff from Chapter 2

1. Citations to Justify Purpose & Questions
2. Citations to Justify Method Choices

12. **FINALIZE** DOCUMENT

1. Front Matter
2. Chapters 1, 2, 3
3. References,
4. Appendixes (measures, consent forms, etc.)

The Twelve Steps Revisited

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|-----------------------|-----------------------|
| 1. Purpose | 7. Outline Method |
| 2. Research Questions | 8. Chapter 3 |
| 3. Gather Sources | 9. Outline Literature |
| 4. Organize Sources | 10. Chapter 2 |
| 5. Justify | 11. Revise All |
| 6. Chapter 1 | 12. Finalize Document |